

Reborn, redone, rethink

As Digit starts its twelfth year on its crazy journey through the gigantic world that is technology, I took a little time off to re-read some of the older issues*. We sure have come a long way, and I don't mean just the magazine, I mean you, me, technology, India, everything.

Most of the queries we got from our readers back then were troubleshooting in nature, because we were still getting used to technology, and screwed up often while using it. The focus gradually shifted to how to use, more than anything else, as PCs became commonplace – at least amongst our readers. Everyone was looking to improve skills and become a whiz. Fast forward to today, and all of the confusion seems to be about what to buy, given all of the myriad options available to us. Of course people still struggle with new technologies, and want to enhance skills, and we continue to try our best to provide that information to you.

Traditionally, changes in trends were easily visible to us by closely watching what the early adopters we up to – the geeks, the enthusiasts...you. Yes, you, as Digit readers, and people who were passionate about technology were the trendsetters. Not anymore.

With technology no longer niche in any sense whatsoever, it's the masses that drive adoption of standards and trends. Facebook is the runaway success that, say, Anand Tech could never be. Thanks to Google, nothing you want is ever more than a few clicks away, and Apple rules the technology world because they simplified everything.

That's not all though, because we've gone from being a "cool" minority of trendsetters, to those few irritating chaps that actually know the difference between a good product and a bad one.

Although the cover story isn't really about this, I think it's still important that people understand where technology is headed.

Every third IT student I know of wants to be a "developer". Everyone with a desire to do business wants to develop apps, because that's where the money is. However, no one seems to have a clue as to what the public really wants...

It's at a time like this where it's true creativity that will win the day. True success here in India will not come anymore from giving people what they want, because people don't really know what that is anymore.

The real genius is to figure out what people *need*, even *before* they realise it themselves.

We can't sit around being a me too anymore. That worked when we were able to undercut everyone and offer them a cheaper rate – a good deal. Everything but hardware is free now; Google, Facebook, Twitter, etc have seen to that. Besides, we never paid for a few million lines of code before, so why would we pay for a few thousand that run on a phone?

Advertising and mining your data is where the real money is, and all that's needed is a hook to get you to use an app, service or site. It's all just about what's popular, what's cool.

What does this mean for the rest of us though? If the masses aren't interested in gaming on 4K resolutions, does that mean GPU manufacturers will focus only on tablets? If low-power and long battery life is all that counts, where do we performance junkies get our fix? Perhaps all of us in the geek business are going to be forced to go the Facebook way or die.

That doesn't mean we have to go quietly into the night, of course. Just because all you see around you are products and advertising that are targeted at the general public, doesn't mean you should assume the big names will not listen to you. Neither does it mean that this magazine will dumb down to pander to them either. A readership of 2,75,000+ might seem like a drop in an ocean of 1.1 billion, but it's still the largest group of technology enthusiasts in India.

As much as we'd like to, we obviously can't make sure everyone of you is heard, but we certainly want to try and get some of you to come with us to press conferences, meet with industry heads, use their products – sometimes before they're even launched to the general public. We want to encourage some of you to write for us, to offer us your opinions, to be heard above the noise that is being produced by mass advertising blitzkriegs. How? Turn to page 77 for a simple URL that will give you those details. Only 50 of you will make the list, but I promise you, they will be the best representatives of this Digit family that we can find. 



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"If the masses aren't interested in gaming on 4K resolutions, does that mean GPU manufacturers will focus only on tablets?"

* Find all past issues of Digit and Fast Track (until December 2011) on the DVDs.

Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and let me know your thoughts.